

Action-Specific History in Present Choice and Initiation: Separating Provenance Discriminability from Repeated-Action History

Abstract

Past behavior influences future behavior through established routes including source memory, episodic retrieval, habit, value learning, and recent action history. The broad proposition that history matters is not the contribution. This theoretical article asks whether distinct informational relations to a person's own prior actions can be manipulated separately while the immediate action problem is held sufficiently fixed, and whether those relations make independently testable contributions to present action. Test A manipulates encoding-stage source diagnosticity for equally familiar self-chosen and seen-but-not-chosen options, independently validates source discrimination and generic recognition, and asks whether later option weighting changes. Test B manipulates context-specific accumulated history of performing the same present action, crosses that history with anticipated future recurrence, and measures bounded self-timed onset alongside a temporally yoked externally triggered comparison. Established source-monitoring, self-action-memory, habit, context-response, and action-history findings are treated as precedents rather than discoveries. The two tests are not assumed to share a lower-level mechanism. Their proposed unity is an experimental identification discipline: distinguish the present action problem from the historical relation, validate the manipulation independently, preserve alternative latent routes, and retain branch-specific failure conditions. The article proposes future experiments and reports no new participant data. Test A, Test B, and their higher-level composition remain open, and exact paper-level originality is not asserted as established.

Keywords: action history; source memory; source monitoring; episodic memory; action control; action initiation; habit; decision making

1. Introduction

A familiar situation can pose a question that a genuinely new situation cannot pose in the same form: Have I been in this situation before, and what did I do?

The second half of that question is not redundant. Recognizing an object, option, or setting does not establish which action a person previously took toward it. An item can be familiar while the person remains uncertain whether it was selected, rejected, merely inspected, or encountered in another episode. Conversely, prior action can be perfectly clear while a different historical relation becomes relevant. A repeated activity may present no uncertainty at all about what has been done before; instead, the current instance may occur against a deep context-specific history of doing the same thing again and again.

These situations motivate two different scientific problems. In the first, familiarity outruns self-action provenance. In the second, the present action is embedded in a repeated action history whose behavioral effect is not fixed in advance. Repetition can facilitate action through learned context-response relations and recent motor history, can contribute to monotony or boredom, or can have no measurable effect once current conditions are controlled. The scientific issue is therefore not whether history is good or bad for action. It is whether different properties of a person's own action history can be isolated as distinct experimental relations to the present problem.

This question begins from ordinary observations but does not treat introspection as mechanistic evidence. A self-ordered task can become difficult when items remain familiar but it becomes uncertain which were actually selected. A mundane repeated activity can feel easy to

perform once yet difficult to re-enter after many similar instances, while a small contextual change can sometimes alter that experience. Existing science already supplies many conventional explanations for such observations: source monitoring, enactment and self-action memory, episodic retrieval, habit, motor hysteresis, boredom, variety seeking, construal, value, and expectancy. The purpose of the present paper is not to replace those explanations with a new hidden variable.

The broader territory is also well preceded. Past behavior predicts future behavior through multiple routes rather than one universal mechanism (Ouellette & Wood, 1998). Beliefs and representations about one's own past behavior can alter later attitudes and behavioral decisions (Albarracín & Wyer, 2000), and how a past action is represented can affect later memory and action (Hart & Albarracín, 2009). Recent voluntary action history can influence present choice (Phillips et al., 2018), and recent hand-use history can bias both hand choice and the time required to initiate a response (Valyear et al., 2019). These findings rule out any paper-level claim that "past self-action affects future action" is new.

The residual question is narrower:

How do distinct, action-specific relations between the present situation and a person's own prior actions alter present selection and initiation when the immediate action problem is held sufficiently fixed?

Two proposed tests make the question empirically contractible.

Test A concerns source/provenance discriminability. Among equally familiar prior encounters, can an experiment change how distinguishable "I chose or acted on this" is from "I merely encountered this," and does that source relation alter current option weighting?

Test B concerns context-specific repeated-action history. Can an experiment change which repeated history of performing the same present action is associated with the current trial, and does that history alter bounded self-timed action onset separately from anticipated future recurrence and externally triggered execution?

The tests may depend on different established lower-level processes. Test A may be explained by source monitoring, confidence, choice-supportive reconstruction, or value-linked memory. Test B may be explained by habit, retrieval fluency, boredom, task-context compatibility, expectation, or other conventional processes. The proposal does not require a common mechanism. The possible unity is at a higher scientific level: both tests manipulate a property of the relation between a present action problem and the person's own prior actions, while attempting to keep the immediate problem itself sufficiently stable.

This paper is therefore an integrative theoretical article with a falsifiable empirical program. It reports no participant data. The effects proposed below remain open. The paper succeeds only if the shared organization does more prospective scientific work than the generic statement that experience influences behavior.

2. Scientific Scope and Declared Boundary

The owned level of analysis is cognitive and behavioral. The relevant objects are self-action memory and source relations, context-specific action history, present option weighting, bounded self-timed action onset, and the interventions needed to distinguish those relations experimentally. The framework does not identify a neural implementation, a dedicated memory store, a universal history cost, a general novelty system, or a hidden task-initiation stage.

Several inferential separations are required throughout. A state can be present without being accessed; accessed information need not be used; used information need not be

authoritative for selection or action; a representation need not causally participate in the process of interest; causal participation does not establish selection; and selection does not guarantee realization. Most importantly for the present paper, a behavioral endpoint does not identify the internal route that generated it. The same final choice or onset latency can be compatible with several latent organizations.

The term action-specific historical relation is therefore intentionally descriptive. It refers to an experimentally declared relation between the current task and information about the person's own prior actions. It does not name a mechanism. The paper does not require a notation such as a latent history variable because no single internal quantity has been established. Avoiding such notation also prevents an analytical grouping from being mistaken for a biological or cognitive module.

The present work is also deliberately nonclinical. Individual differences or clinical populations may later provide useful tests, but attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder, obsessive-compulsive disorder, addiction, procrastination, and related constructs are not explanatory targets here. The general architecture must stand or fall in ordinary cognitive and behavioral experiments before any population-specific extension is justified.

3. What Is Already Established

3.1 Past behavior reaches future behavior through multiple routes

Ouellette and Wood (1998) synthesized evidence that past behavior predicts future behavior through more than one process. Under stable conditions and extensive practice, past behavior can index habit strength and support relatively automatic recurrence. Under less stable or less practiced conditions, past behavior may contribute through conscious intentions and

decision processes. This is already a broad history-to-action framework. The present paper therefore cannot claim that behavior is "history-relative" in the generic sense.

Related work shows that cognition about one's own past behavior can itself change what happens next. Albarracín and Wyer (2000) experimentally altered what participants believed about their prior behavior and showed downstream consequences for beliefs, attitudes, and later behavioral decisions. Hart and Albarracín (2009) showed that grammatical framing of a past action as ongoing versus completed can alter memory and later action-related responses. These studies are especially important because they show that a behavioral history is not scientifically exhausted by a count of past occurrences; how that history is represented can matter.

The residual burden is therefore not to show that the past matters. It is to identify whether two narrower informational properties of self-action history can be manipulated separately while the current action problem is sufficiently controlled.

3.2 Familiarity is not self-action provenance

Source-monitoring theory distinguishes memory for information from judgments about its origin (Johnson et al., 1993). An item can be recognized as old while its source remains uncertain. Mather, Shafir, and Johnson (2000) further showed that memory for features of previously considered options can be distorted in a choice-supportive direction, demonstrating that source judgments about a decision history can themselves be reconstructed rather than passively replayed.

The distinction becomes especially important for actions. The enactment literature shows that performing actions can improve later memory relative to passive conditions under many designs (Roberts et al., 2022). Thus, self-action is not assumed to be a weak encoding condition.

The relevant point is more specific: successful item recognition or even good action memory does not guarantee accurate attribution of which action occurred in which episode.

Hornstein and Mulligan (2004) provide direct precedent for treating action/source memory as experimentally manipulable rather than identical to item memory. Their work compared self-performed and observed actions and examined source memory as a distinct outcome. The present Test A uses that general source-diagnostics logic without claiming ownership of source monitoring or enactment effects.

Direct neighboring work narrows the bridge further. Dougherty and Franco-Watkins (2003) improved source monitoring through encoding and item-context manipulations and obtained more accurate downstream frequency judgments, so the generic bridge from source diagnostics to later judgment is already precedented. Schaper et al. (2019) found that source memory and item recognition were differently associated with later adaptive social decisions. A contemporary review likewise places episodic memory for self-actions and decisions in learning about one's own habits and preferences (Mazor et al., 2026). Repeated-event research shows that recurrence can support source and destination misattributions across instances (Rubínová & Kontogianni, 2023). Together, these findings block any claim that self-action source memory or source-memory-to-decision relations are unexplored. The residual Test A question is narrower: whether encoding-stage discriminability of self-chosen versus merely encountered but equally familiar options changes later option weighting under the specified controls.

Self-ordered monitoring provides an additional precedent. Provost, Petrides, and Monchi (2010) studied conditions in which participants had to keep track of their own previous selections rather than merely recognize stimuli. The important functional point is straightforward: "I have seen this" and "I already selected this" answer different questions. That distinction is established;

whether experimentally changing its discriminability alters a later choice distribution is not thereby settled.

3.3 Prior decisions can be retrieved and made behaviorally relevant

Episodic decision work provides a direct route from specific prior episodes to current choice. Bornstein et al. (2017) showed that reminders of previous decisions can bias later reward choices. Bornstein and Norman (2017) showed that reinstated episodic context can guide which prior decisions are sampled in current reward choice. These findings establish that present decisions can depend on which prior episodes are made accessible or relevant.

Again, this is not the present paper's contribution. The importance of this literature is constraining. A proposed effect of action history does not require a novel retrieval mechanism. If Test A or Test B succeeds, established episodic or contextual retrieval may fully explain the route. The present question concerns what historical relation is manipulated and what present behavior changes, not whether the mediator must be proprietary.

3.4 Repetition can facilitate action

Any account motivated by resistance to repeated tasks must begin by conceding the opposite direction. Repetition often facilitates behavior. Habit accounts describe how stable contexts can acquire control over repeated responses, reducing dependence on deliberative selection (Wood & Neal, 2007). Recent motor history can also bias present choice and speed action. Valyear et al. (2019) found that recent hand choice influenced current hand choice and that repeated hand choice reduced response time to initiate action when response costs were comparable.

Phillips et al. (2018) likewise showed that monitoring recent voluntary actions is relevant to present voluntary choice. Their findings remove novelty from the general idea that recent action history can guide current selection.

Wagner et al. (2026) provide a particularly close current constraint. In a task combining habit induction with goal-directed demands under time pressure, habitual influence varied with the number of repetitions, participants modulated habit use according to context and goal congruence, and the authors modeled consequences for choices and reaction times. Thus the generic proposition that repetition strength and context can alter current action or latency is already precedented. Test B must earn a narrower residual by separating accumulated same-action history from anticipated future recurrence and by testing bounded self-timed onset against a timing-matched external comparison.

These precedents impose a critical constraint on Test B. The experiment cannot assume that a deeper repeated-action history will slow or inhibit onset. Facilitation, inhibition, and null effects are all scientifically legitimate. A facilitation result may be especially consistent with ordinary context-response learning, motor history, or fluency. It can still demonstrate sensitivity to history, but it would contract the motivating mundane-resistance interpretation.

3.5 Repetition can also change engagement and variety seeking

A second conventional route runs through monotony, boredom, and variety. Shen and Wyer (2010) showed that past behavior can influence later variety-seeking strategies through both automatic and deliberative processes. Fishbach, Ratner, and Zhang (2011) showed that framing repetition in positive versus negative terms can shift consistency versus variety seeking through different construals of repeated consumption. Iso-Ahola (2022) explicitly addresses

everyday repetitive behavior, including easy tasks that can become difficult under monotony, while emphasizing that repetition can also support automaticity.

Action construal is another established route. McCrea et al. (2008) found that more concrete construal reduced procrastination and that the effect was not explained by task attractiveness, importance, or perceived difficulty. Accordingly, a context or history manipulation that changes how the present task is represented can alter initiation without identifying a distinct history mechanism.

These findings mean that a small contextual change making a routine action feel easier is not, by itself, evidence for a new history mechanism. Ordinary boredom reduction, variety, preference, event boundaries, or construal may be sufficient. In the current framework those are not nuisances to be erased automatically; they are candidate explanations that should remain visible if a manipulation changes behavior.

3.6 Generic memory difficulty does not imply more novelty seeking

The paper also rejects a tempting but overly general bridge from memory difficulty to novelty or exploration. Brown et al. (2022) found that cognitive constraints in a multi-armed bandit task can reduce directed exploration rather than increase it. That result does not determine what a selective self-action provenance manipulation will do, but it blocks the generic theory that poorer memory should produce more exploration.

Accordingly, Test A uses novel-option weighting only as a possible outcome within a source-specific design. It does not label novel-option selection as directed exploration unless information seeking is separately operationalized.

4. The Residual Scientific Problem

The literature above leaves a narrow but testable residual. Past action can influence current action; source memory can differ from recognition; episodic context can guide present choice; repetition can create habits, biases, boredom, and variety seeking. The remaining question is whether distinct informational properties of self-action history can be manipulated as separate relations to an otherwise similar present action problem.

The distinction proposed here is not between "history present" and "history absent." Instead, two properties are isolated.

The first is source/provenance discriminability: among equally familiar encounters, how well can a person discriminate items that were previously self-chosen or acted on from items that were merely encountered?

The second is context-specific repeated-action history: given the same current action, what depth of prior same-action experience is associated with the current context, and how does that relation affect self-timed entry into the action when anticipated future recurrence is controlled separately?

These are different manipulations. Test A holds oldness approximately constant while changing the discriminability of self-action source. Test B holds the current action constant while changing its learned relation to a context and, where feasible, the depth of that relation. Their observable targets also differ: option weighting versus onset latency. Each can fail independently.

The proposed composition earns survival only if this distinction changes experimental practice. It must tell the experimenter what to manipulate, what to match, what to measure, what

alternative explanations to preserve, and what result kills each branch. If it merely renames two existing effects as "history," it adds nothing.

5. Test A: Source/Provenance Discriminability and Present Option Weighting

5.1 Identification target

Test A asks whether source identity among equally familiar prior encounters has behavioral consequences beyond generic old/new familiarity.

The design distinguishes three item states:

C - familiar and previously self-chosen or acted on;

S - familiar and previously seen or encountered but not self-chosen;

N - genuinely new.

C and S are both old. Their critical difference is source relation to the participant's prior action. N serves as a new-option comparison, not as an automatic measure of exploration.

The test does not ask whether participants can remember anything about the earlier episode. It asks whether experimentally changing C-versus-S source discriminability, while keeping old/new recognition and current value as stable as feasible, changes the later distribution of choice.

5.2 Encoding-stage source-diagnosticity manipulation

The core manipulation occurs at encoding rather than by replaying or reminding participants of their prior choices at the final decision.

Participants first encounter matched option sets under conditions in which some items become C and others S. C and S items should be matched as tightly as feasible for exposure

duration, perceptual familiarity, current reward or value, and motor or attentional engagement not intrinsic to the source distinction itself.

Source diagnosticity is then varied between conditions during the original episode.

In a high-diagnosticity condition, contextual or source features associated with self-chosen versus seen-only encounters are distinct enough to support later C/S discrimination. For example, source-relevant contextual features can differ systematically between chosen and seen-only events.

In a low-diagnosticity condition, matched contextual stimulation is still present, but the features overlap, are shared, or otherwise provide little information about whether the item was chosen versus merely seen. The manipulation therefore changes diagnosticity rather than simply adding more sensory stimulation in one condition.

The source cues are removed before the final choice phase. Participants are not told or reminded at that point which options they chose earlier. This restriction is essential because an explicit prior-choice reminder could influence later selection through self-consistency, self-perception, demand, choice-supportive reconstruction, or a direct instruction-like route rather than through the source relation of interest.

Hornstein and Mulligan (2004) provide methodological precedent for treating action/source memory as separable from item memory. Dougherty and Franco-Watkins (2003) further show that encoding and item-context manipulations can improve source monitoring and downstream judgment. These precedents support the manipulability of source diagnosticity; they do not establish the narrower effect of self-action provenance on later option weighting. The exact stimuli and contextual source cues in a final implementation should therefore be

preregistered and validated rather than assumed to instantiate a universal source-diagnostics manipulation.

5.3 Manipulation validity

The manipulation must earn interpretation before any downstream choice result is considered.

First, C/S source discrimination should be measurably better in the high-diagnostics than in the low-diagnostics condition. This can be assessed on separate trials, a separate block, or by another design that does not contaminate the final choice trial with an explicit source reminder.

Second, old/new item recognition for C and S versus N should remain approximately matched across diagnostics conditions. Exact equality is unnecessary, but a manipulation that materially changes generic item memory cannot be interpreted as source-specific without an explicit measurement model accounting for that difference.

Third, current subjective value should be measured or experimentally fixed sufficiently to rule out the trivial explanation that one condition changed which items are currently more rewarding. If source features themselves acquire value, that fact must be acknowledged as part of the manipulation rather than silently treated as pure source information.

Confidence may also be measured because source confidence can influence choice, but confidence is not synonymous with provenance. A confidence effect is one possible route, not the target's definition.

If the manipulation changes C/S discrimination only by changing old/new recognition or present value inseparably, Test A is invalid under that implementation.

5.4 Final choice and primary outcomes

After source cues have been removed, participants choose among C, S, and N options under matched current incentives.

The primary outcome is the full choice distribution:

$P(C)$, $P(S)$, and $P(N)$.

Two contrasts should be specified in advance because they answer different questions.

The first is prior-choice consistency, captured conceptually by $P(C) - P(S)$. A change here indicates that source diagnosticity altered weighting between two familiar classes that differ in prior self-action status.

The second is novel-option weighting, captured by $P(N)$ relative to an appropriate familiar-option aggregate or by a preregistered model-based contrast. A shift toward N is a stronger and more specific extension because it would indicate that altered source discriminability changes the balance between familiar-history options and a genuinely new alternative.

The design should not collapse these outcomes. If diagnosticity changes only C versus S, a repeat-choice or choice-supportive account may be sufficient and the novelty-related subclaim should contract. The provenance-to-choice bridge could still survive in a weaker form.

If lower source discriminability increases relative N weighting while item recognition and current value remain sufficiently matched, and higher diagnosticity contracts that difference, then the stronger provenance-to-novel-option relation would receive empirical support. Even then, the result would not identify directed exploration or a unique mechanism.

5.5 Alternative explanations and observational equivalence

A Test A choice shift remains compatible with several latent routes.

Choice consistency is an obvious possibility: participants may simply prefer options they previously chose. Mather et al. (2000) further show that choice can distort later source attribution, so source reports may partly reflect downstream reconstruction rather than a pristine record of the earlier event. Self-perception or demand may also encourage consistency with a known prior choice if the design leaks that information at test.

Retrieval fluency and confidence can vary with diagnosticity and can themselves affect decisions. Source features may alter subjective value. Participants may infer what they "must have chosen" from current preferences, especially when source memory is weak. An observed downstream effect therefore does not establish a single source-memory route.

The scientific claim is correspondingly bounded. A valid manipulation can show that changing source diagnosticity at encoding changes later action under controlled conditions. It cannot, from endpoint choice alone, determine whether the active route was explicit source reconstruction, confidence, fluency, value updating, consistency, or a mixture of these processes.

5.6 Test A contraction and kill conditions

Test A should contract or fail under several outcomes.

First, if source diagnosticity reliably changes C/S discrimination but the later choice distribution does not change, the proposed provenance-to-action bridge is killed under that design. Source memory remains scientifically real, but it has not earned the proposed present-action role.

Second, if diagnosticity changes only $P(C)$ relative to $P(S)$ with no credible effect on N weighting, the novelty-related subclaim contracts. A narrower provenance-to-repeat-choice relation may remain.

Third, if old/new recognition changes inseparably with C/S discrimination, the manipulation has not isolated the target relation.

Fourth, if current value differences account for the final choice pattern, a provenance-specific interpretation fails unless a stronger design separates value from source.

Fifth, if explicit reminders, demand, or self-consistency are required to produce the effect, the revised source-diagnostics claim should contract to those established routes rather than be preserved by terminology.

6. Test B: Context-Specific Repeated-Action History and Self-Timed Onset

6.1 Identification target

Test B addresses a different relation. The participant can know exactly what the action is and can execute it successfully. The question is whether the context-specific history of repeatedly performing that same action changes when the action is self-initiated.

The test is not an assay for a hidden initiation module. It does not assume that repeated history is aversive. It asks whether a learned context-action history contributes to the timing of voluntary entry when the immediate action is held sufficiently fixed and anticipated future recurrence is manipulated separately.

6.2 Crossover architecture

A crossover design reduces several simple task-level explanations.

Let S_A and S_B be two equally familiar contexts and X and Y two activities with comparable global exposure, practice, effort, and reward. During training, S_A is paired repeatedly with X, whereas S_B is paired repeatedly with Y. The participant therefore develops a

stronger S_A-X history and a stronger S_B-Y history while both contexts and both actions remain familiar overall.

At test, the current action is held fixed. For example, X is performed under conditions associated with S_A versus S_B, or after a validated cue that selectively activates the learned S_A-X versus S_B-X relation. The immediate instructions, motor requirements, reward, and task content are otherwise matched.

This architecture separates global familiarity with X from the specific history of doing X in the currently relevant context. Because Y receives comparable global practice in the complementary context, the design also reduces the explanation that one action simply became more skilled, boring, or practiced overall.

Where feasible, the design should also manipulate repetition depth. High- and low-depth S-X relations can be created while equating total context exposure with filler activity. This prevents context familiarity from becoming a proxy for same-action repetition.

6.3 Past repetition and anticipated future recurrence

Past repetition must be separated from the expectation that the task will recur again.

"I have done this repeatedly" and "I will have to keep doing this" are distinct temporal relations. Everyday repeated tasks often confound them, but an experiment need not.

Test B therefore independently crosses accumulated past repetition with expected future recurrence. In a recurrence condition, participants expect additional same-action trials after the current trial. In a one-off condition, the present trial is the last instance of that action, while total remaining experimental workload is matched by replacing future same-action trials with other work of comparable duration or demand.

This creates conditions in which a participant can have high past repetition but low future recurrence, low past repetition but high future recurrence, both, or neither. The design thereby avoids interpreting prospective obligation, expected boredom, or a long remaining workload as if it were necessarily an effect of accumulated past history.

If only anticipated recurrence predicts onset, the historical claim should contract toward prospective expectation or obligation. If past repetition retains an effect after recurrence is separated, the context-specific historical relation has stronger support.

6.4 Bounded self-timed onset

The primary endpoint is bounded self-timed action onset.

A trial makes the target task available under a preregistered onset window, and the participant is allowed to initiate within that window without being told to start at a fixed moment. The first valid task-directed action defines onset. The primary latency is measured from task availability to that first valid action.

This design should not use the rejected contrast between "begin when ready" and "begin immediately" as if the difference localized an internal initiation stage. Such instructions change urgency, permission to wait, criterion, demand, and timing policy.

Instead, Test B pairs self-timed trials with a yoked externally triggered control. External cue times are taken from the participant's own previously observed self-generated onset times or from a defensible counterbalanced distribution matched to those timings. The post-cue motor action and task are otherwise the same. This better matches temporal opportunity while changing whether onset timing is internally selected or externally triggered.

The relevant outcomes are therefore separate:

1. self-timed onset latency from task availability;

2. externally triggered reaction time after the yoked cue; and
3. post-onset execution accuracy or speed.

A history-associated effect on self-timed onset with a different or null effect on yoked post-cue reaction time would demonstrate condition selectivity under matched timing opportunity. It would not prove that a discrete internal "initiation stage" was selectively affected.

Jahanshahi et al. (1995) provide a classic precedent for distinguishing self-initiated from externally triggered movement, and Khalighinejad et al. (2018) provide a modern self-initiated-action paradigm that reinforces the need to treat self-initiated and externally triggered conditions as different task regimes rather than as labels for a hidden stage. Valyear et al. (2019) show directly that recent action history can influence both action selection and initiation time. These precedents motivate the measurement distinction without establishing the present context-specific repeated-history hypothesis.

6.5 Manipulation validity

A context cue is not automatically evidence that a repeated-action history has been reinstated. The strongest language licensed by the design depends on an independent measure.

That requirement is established rather than novel. Labrecque et al. (2024) introduced an objective paradigm for measuring learned context-response associations while controlling goal-pursuit motivation. Their work therefore precedents the use of an independent measure of a context-response relation rather than treating the endpoint behavior as sufficient evidence that the relation was instantiated. Test B adopts that established measurement discipline; it does not claim that context-response associations exist or can be measured as a new contribution.

If separate measurements show that a cue differentially retrieves or activates the intended context-action relation, then "history retrieval" or "reinstatement" may be defensible. Without

such evidence, the manuscript should state only that a learned cue associated with a repeated action history altered behavior.

Manipulation checks might assess memory for the context-action pairing, context-specific action expectancy, or another preregistered index that bears directly on the learned relation. The measure must not simply be the same onset effect being explained.

Current value, perceived difficulty, fatigue, and immediate reward should also be measured or controlled as needed. These variables are not automatically confounds; they may be legitimate routes by which historical experience becomes behaviorally important. The critical requirement is that the causal language match what the design can identify.

6.6 Direction and interpretation

The sign of Test B is intentionally open.

An inhibition result - longer self-timed onset in the context carrying deeper same-action history - would support the motivating mundane-resistance direction, subject to alternative explanations such as boredom, expectation, or value.

A facilitation result would reject or contract that direction while remaining scientifically informative. It could align with habit, fluency, recent action history, or learned context-response control. Valyear et al. (2019) make such facilitation a serious prior expectation rather than an inconvenient result.

A null result under a valid manipulation would kill the proposed repeated-history initiation relation for the tested conditions. The framework should not preserve the branch by appealing to an unmeasured latent history variable.

6.7 Alternative explanations and observational equivalence

A Test B onset effect can be generated through many routes. Learned context-response associations, retrieval fluency, anticipated boredom, current boredom, context preference, task-context compatibility, fatigue, reward history, repetition priming, perceived obligation, expectancy, or demand can all produce a similar endpoint.

Marinovic et al. (2017) provide a direct reason not to infer one action-history route from an endpoint. By manipulating movement preparation time and predictable movement sequences, they dissociated a relatively stable bias tied to recent movement history from a dynamically evolving, context-dependent predictive-planning contribution. Test B does not reproduce that design, but it inherits the identification lesson: an onset effect can remain compatible with separable recent-use/history and predictive/contextual processes, among other conventional routes.

The design should distinguish where possible, but it should not pretend that every mediator must be eliminated. If repeated history changes onset because it increases anticipated boredom, that may be a correct conventional explanation. If it speeds onset through habit, that may be the correct explanation. The paper does not require a residual unexplained effect after established mechanisms are included.

Statistical mediation should therefore be described as consistent with a route unless the mediator itself is experimentally manipulated under assumptions sufficient for stronger causal inference. An interaction between history condition and self-timed versus externally triggered trials likewise demonstrates selectivity, not a hidden stage.

6.8 Test B contraction and kill conditions

Test B should contract or fail if any of the following occur.

First, a valid context-action manipulation produces no change in self-timed onset. The repeated-history initiation claim is then killed for that implementation.

Second, robust facilitation appears instead of inhibition. The broader statement that onset is history-sensitive may survive, but the motivating mundane-resistance direction is killed or sharply contracted.

Third, only expected future recurrence matters. In that case the phenomenon belongs primarily to prospective expectation, obligation, or anticipated boredom rather than accumulated past repetition.

Fourth, arbitrary salient cues with no learned same-action history reproduce the effect. History-specific interpretation then fails.

Fifth, the effect reduces entirely to ordinary context-response facilitation and shows no meaningful distinction in self-timed onset beyond what established habit models already predict. The broader initiation framing should contract to that conventional account.

7. Why Tests A and B May Belong in One Paper

The most important compositional question is whether Test A and Test B genuinely instantiate one higher-level scientific problem or merely sit near one another because both involve memory and action.

Their lower-level mechanisms are not enough to unify them. Test A is likely to recruit source-monitoring and decision-memory processes; Test B may recruit habit, episodic context, boredom, expectancy, or motor history. Forcing them into one mechanism would add an unsupported bridge and make the paper weaker.

The proposed unity is instead defined by four shared constraints.

First, each test manipulates a specific property of the person's own prior action history rather than merely comparing old and new behavior. Test A changes how well self-chosen history can be distinguished from seen-only history. Test B changes the context-specific depth or association of repeated same-action history.

Second, each test attempts to keep the immediate action problem sufficiently fixed. Test A matches C and S for familiarity, exposure, and current value while manipulating source diagnosticity. Test B holds the present action constant while varying its learned relation to context and separates that history from future recurrence.

Third, each test has an independently validated historical manipulation and an observable present-action consequence. Source discrimination is not inferred from final choice; context-action retrieval is not inferred from onset latency. This separation blocks circular identification.

Fourth, each branch has independent failure conditions. Test A can fail while Test B survives, and vice versa. Success in one does not validate the other.

These shared constraints make "distinct, action-specific historical relations available for present use" more than a label only if they guide experimental design prospectively. The abstraction should tell researchers to distinguish familiarity from provenance, repetition from anticipated recurrence, manipulation validity from endpoint behavior, and condition selectivity from mechanism identification.

A compact way to state the composition is therefore:

Test A changes which prior encounter can be attributed to the person's own action.

Test B changes which repeated same-action history is linked to the present context.

Both ask whether changing that historical relation, without changing the immediate action problem more than necessary, changes present action.

The composition remains open until empirical work shows that this organization earns value across both tests. If the only result is that each branch reproduces an already known effect under a different label, the single-paper abstraction should contract.

8. Strongest Conventional Reductions and Same-Level Prior Art

A serious account must survive reduction to established science rather than treating known components as novelty deficits.

8.1 Reduction of Test A

Test A can be described using source monitoring, action memory, choice-supportive reconstruction, confidence, value, and repeat-choice consistency. Johnson et al. (1993), Mather et al. (2000), Roberts et al. (2022), Hornstein and Mulligan (2004), and Mazor et al. (2026) supply established machinery for self-action/source memory and its fallibility. Rubínová and Kontogianni (2023) further show that repeated-event recall can contain systematic source and destination misattributions.

Phillips et al. (2018) remove novelty from the broad proposition that recent voluntary action history can guide present choice. Albarracín and Wyer (2000) and Hart and Albarracín (2009) remove novelty from the broader idea that representations of past behavior can alter future behavior. Dougherty and Franco-Watkins (2003) directly precedent the intervention bridge from improved source diagnosticity to improved downstream judgment, while Schaper et al. (2019) show that source memory and item recognition can bear differently on adaptive decisions. A generic source-memory-to-later-behavior claim is therefore precedent.

What remains open in Test A is narrower: encoding-stage manipulation of discriminability between self-chosen or acted-on and merely encountered but equally familiar

options, with generic recognition, current value, and explicit-reminder routes separated as far as the design permits, followed by later option weighting. The proposed result would not identify a new source process or a unique causal route.

8.2 Reduction of Test B

Test B can be described using context-response learning, habit, episodic context, motor/action history, repetition priming, repetition-based fluency or facilitation, predictive preparation/planning, current value, boredom, monotony, expectation, anticipated recurrence, obligation, action construal, timing policy, and self-initiated action paradigms. Ouellette and Wood (1998) and Wood and Neal (2007) establish broad routes from repeated past behavior and stable context to future behavior. Valyear et al. (2019) show that recent choice history can affect both present choice and initiation time. Wagner et al. (2026) provide an especially close current neighbor: repetition strength modulated habitual influence, behavior was context dependent, and choice and reaction-time consequences were modeled under time pressure. Marinovic et al. (2017) further show that observed action-history effects on subsequent movement can reflect separable recent-action-history and context-dependent predictive-planning processes as preparation conditions vary. Generic context-specific repetition and action-history effects on current action or latency are therefore strongly precedented.

Shen and Wyer (2010), Fishbach et al. (2011), Iso-Ahola (2022), and McCrea et al. (2008) establish conventional routes through variety seeking, framing, monotony, boredom, and action construal. Jahanshahi et al. (1995) and Khalighinejad et al. (2018) provide established methodological precedent for distinguishing self-initiated from externally triggered action. Labrecque et al. (2024) establish that learned context-response associations can be measured objectively while goal-pursuit motivation is controlled, so Test B's requirement to validate the

context-action relation independently of the onset endpoint is preceded measurement practice rather than a new methodological discovery. These established accounts may fully explain any Test B effect.

What remains open in Test B is not a new initiation mechanism, a new context-response association, or a new way to measure one. It is the combined prospective test that independently validates context-specific same-action history, separates accumulated past repetition from anticipated future recurrence, holds the current action sufficiently fixed, and compares bounded self-timed onset with a temporally matched or yoked externally triggered condition without treating endpoint selectivity as identifying a unique route or hidden stage.

8.3 Paper-level residual

After granting those direct neighbors, the paper-level residual remains organizational and experimental rather than mechanistic. The proposed cross-branch discipline factorizes different action-specific historical relations, validates the historical manipulation independently of the endpoint, measures a present-action consequence, and retains branch-specific failure conditions without inferring one common mechanism.

That residual must remain modest. The bounded review has not identified a source that substantially assembles the exact Test A and Test B functions to answer the same larger question, but absence of such a match is not proof of originality. Test A, Test B, and the A+B composition therefore remain open, and exact paper-level novelty is not asserted as established.

9. Identification Limits and Observational Equivalence

The central scientific discipline of the framework is to keep observation, measurement, inference, and mechanism separate.

A final choice is an endpoint. The same $P(C)$, $P(S)$, $P(N)$ pattern can arise through different combinations of source reconstruction, confidence, retrieval fluency, value, consistency, demand, or item memory. A Test A manipulation may narrow this equivalence class, but it does not eliminate it automatically.

An onset latency is likewise an endpoint. The same delay can arise from boredom, expectation, habit conflict, task switching, uncertainty, fatigue, value, or timing policy. A self-timed versus yoked external interaction can show that the effect is condition-selective, but it does not identify an internal action stage.

This matters because several tempting inferences are stronger than the experiments license.

Source discrimination present does not imply that source information is used in the final choice.

Source information used does not imply that it is authoritative relative to value or other decision inputs.

A context-action association present does not imply that it was retrieved on a particular test trial unless retrieval is independently measured.

A retrieved history does not imply that it caused the onset difference.

A selected action does not imply successful execution, and successful execution does not retrospectively certify how the action was selected.

Multiple latent organizations can therefore remain observationally equivalent after each proposed experiment. This is not a flaw to be hidden. It sets the claim ceiling. The appropriate result is often a narrowed causal or functional statement plus a list of remaining routes, not a unique mechanistic explanation.

10. Predictions, Failure Conditions, and Scientific Contraction

The framework is intentionally designed to lose explanatory territory when evidence does not require it.

10.1 Test A

The minimal Test A prediction is that a valid source-diagnostics manipulation changes later weighting among C and S. The stronger subordinate prediction is that lower provenance discriminability can increase relative weighting of N beyond a C-versus-S repeat-choice effect.

The branch contracts if only prior-choice consistency changes. It fails if source discrimination changes but present option weighting does not. It is invalid if the manipulation materially changes generic item recognition or current value in a way that cannot be separated from source diagnostics.

10.2 Test B

The minimal Test B prediction is not a direction but sensitivity: under a valid context-action manipulation, self-timed onset may differ as a function of context-specific repeated-action history. Inhibition, facilitation, and null outcomes are all interpretable.

Inhibition supports the motivating mundane-resistance direction but requires discrimination from boredom, expectation, value, and related routes. Facilitation contracts that direction toward habit, fluency, or motor-history explanations. Null results kill the repeated-history onset claim under the tested conditions. If only future recurrence matters, the historical claim contracts to prospective expectation or obligation.

10.3 Composition

The A+B composition fails if the only shared conclusion is that past behavior affects future behavior. That proposition is already established and does not justify a new framework.

The common object also fails if it does not generate shared prospective discipline. If Test A and Test B require unrelated definitions, unrelated controls, unrelated failure logic, and no common distinction between the present action problem and historical relation, then they should be treated as separate conventional effects rather than preserved as one theory.

Conversely, empirical success in both tests would still not establish a shared lower-level mechanism. It would support the more modest claim that at least two separable properties of self-action history can be manipulated under controlled present problems and can make different contributions to current action.

11. Limits

Several limits are central rather than peripheral.

First, the manuscript reports no participant data. Every effect in Tests A and B is proposed, not demonstrated.

Second, the paper does not define a new memory system, controller, initiation stage, novelty mechanism, or neural architecture. Established component science retains explanatory priority.

Third, the framework is boundary- and task-relative. A historical relation that matters in one task may be irrelevant in another. The experiments must declare which prior actions, contexts, source features, and outcomes are included.

Fourth, Test A does not equate familiarity with source memory, and it does not equate novel-option selection with directed exploration. Information seeking would require a separate operationalization.

Fifth, Test B does not assume that repetition impairs action. Facilitation is a legitimate outcome and a major conventional alternative.

Sixth, past repetition and anticipated future recurrence must remain distinct unless evidence supports merger. Everyday co-occurrence is not sufficient reason to collapse them experimentally.

Seventh, a selective self-timed effect does not identify an internal initiation stage. The yoked external-trigger condition is a control for timing opportunity and execution, not a biological localization assay.

Eighth, statistical mediation is not causal proof without stronger intervention and identification assumptions.

Ninth, the human observations that motivated the paper are explanatory examples, not empirical evidence for the proposed architecture.

Finally, the composition itself is falsifiable. If direct prior-art review shows that an existing framework already assembles substantially the same pieces to answer substantially the same larger question at the same level, the paper-level contribution should be treated as subsumed. If experiments show that the common historical organization adds no explanatory or predictive value beyond existing task-specific accounts, the framework should contract accordingly.

12. Conclusion

The past relevant to present action is not a single quantity. A person can recognize an option without knowing whether they previously chose it. The same person can also face a completely unambiguous action whose current instance is embedded in a deep history of doing the same thing in the same context. These relations are different even though both concern prior behavior.

Existing science already explains why past behavior influences future behavior, why source memory can diverge from familiarity, why episodic context can guide choice, why repetition can build habits, why action history can bias present responding, and why monotony and variety can change engagement. The present paper does not claim those mechanisms.

Its narrower proposal is experimental. Test A manipulates source diagnosticity among equally familiar self-chosen and seen-only encounters and asks whether provenance discriminability changes current option weighting. Test B manipulates context-specific repeated same-action history, separates it from expected future recurrence, and asks whether it changes bounded self-timed onset relative to yoked externally triggered execution.

The two tests belong together only if the higher-level organization earns its keep: each must manipulate a distinct historical relation while the present action problem is sufficiently fixed, validate that manipulation independently, preserve observational equivalence where it remains, and fail under explicit conditions.

If those requirements are not met, the framework should dissolve into its established components. If they are met, the result would support a bounded claim: present action can depend not merely on the fact that a person has acted before, but on which specific relation between the current problem and that person's own action history is available for present use.

Declarations

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Competing interests

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Ethics approval

Not applicable. This theoretical article reports no original research involving human participants, human data, human tissue, or animals.

Consent to participate

Not applicable.

Consent for publication

Not applicable.

Availability of data and materials

Data sharing is not applicable to this article because no datasets were generated or analyzed for the present theoretical work.

Code availability

Not applicable. No software or custom code was developed or analyzed for the present theoretical work.

Open Practices Statement

No datasets or experimental materials were generated or analyzed for the present theoretical article, and no experiments reported in this article were preregistered. The article instead proposes future experimental tests.

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